

Practical techniques to stop ruminating and accept the uncontrollable wait — Action Checklist

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GROUNDING YOUR BODY IMMEDIATELY

- ☐ **Grounding Your Body Immediately:** Practice the six-second breath anchor (inhale for four counts, hold for four, exhale slowly) the moment you notice rumination starting, because breath counting requires your prefrontal cortex to handle a task while activating your parasympathetic nervous system to interrupt the spiral before it gains momentum.
- ☐ **Grounding Your Body Immediately:** Close your mouth and inhale through your nose for a count of four when anxiety spikes, then hold for four seconds before exhaling slowly, because the breath hold allows carbon dioxide to build slightly and makes the exhale feel more like release, creating a genuine physiological reset.
- ☐ **Grounding Your Body Immediately:** Notice the early physical signs of spiraling—including tight jaw, raised shoulders, and shallow breathing—and interrupt immediately with directed breathing, because by the time you notice the catastrophic thought, it has typically been running for ten to twenty minutes already.
- ☐ **Grounding Your Body Immediately:** Use the breath-counting technique as a fire alarm rather than a relaxation tool, understanding that its purpose is disruption and reset, not eliminating anxiety, because this reframing prevents you from judging yourself when the technique doesn't make the worry disappear.

ACCEPTING WHAT YOU CANNOT CONTROL

- ☐ **Accepting What You Cannot Control:** Remind yourself multiple times daily that the test results are outside your control and that three days of rumination will not change a single outcome, because acceptance means recognizing that your mental rehearsal has zero effect on medical reality.
 - ☐ **Accepting What You Cannot Control:** Hold "this is out of my hands" without interpreting it as defeat or surrender, because confusing acceptance with defeat keeps you stuck in the belief that trying harder mentally will somehow protect you from the result.
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- ☐ **Accepting What You Cannot Control:** Stop mentally rehearsing conversations with doctors who haven't called yet and imagining survival statistics for conditions you don't have, because these rehearsals are the amygdala hijacking your rational thinking and serving no protective function whatsoever.
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- ☐ **Accepting What You Cannot Control:** Give yourself permission to be deeply uncomfortable without collapsing, understanding that you can function while holding "this situation is outside my control," because the guide's core message is that you don't need to convince yourself to stop worrying—you just need actions to do with the worry once it's there.

PROTECTING YOUR DAYS AND CONNECTIONS

- ☐ **Protecting Your Days and Connections:** Structure your unstructured hours by planning specific activities for each day of the waiting period, because unstructured time becomes rumination time and the wait will otherwise swallow your entire existence.
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- ☐ **Protecting Your Days and Connections:** Set information boundaries by designating one specific time per day to check the patient portal, rather than refreshing every hour, because checking repeatedly trains your nervous system to treat the portal as a threat requiring constant monitoring.
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- ☐ **Protecting Your Days and Connections:** Stay connected to people and resist the instinct to pull away during the waiting period, because isolation intensifies rumination and the human part of surviving this guide is keeping relationships intact while your instinct is to disappear.
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- ☐ **Protecting Your Days and Connections:** Give yourself permission to be less available to others during the wait without guilt or excessive explanation, because the days still exist while you're waiting and you don't owe anyone peak performance during a genuinely difficult period.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.